



LONELINESS & SOCIAL ISOLATION

Understanding disconnection, finding support, and rebuilding meaningful connection.



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Feeling lonely does not mean you are alone. Loneliness is the painful feeling that the connection you have—or want—is not enough. Social isolation is different: it describes having limited contact or interaction with other people. They can overlap, but they are not the same thing.

WHY DOES LONELINESS HURT?

Students and young people can experience loneliness during major transitions, academic pressure, moving away from home, friendship changes, financial stress, or periods of uncertainty. You can even feel lonely while surrounded by people.

Loneliness is not a character flaw. It is a signal that connection, belonging, support, or companionship may need attention.

THOUGHTS TO WATCH FOR

- “Nobody would understand me.”
- “I should just deal with it myself.”
- “Everyone else has close friends.”
- “If I reach out, I will be a burden.”

“Connection does not have to be perfect to be meaningful.”

LONELINESS CAN LOOK DIFFERENT FOR EVERYONE

Notice the signs without judging yourself.

01	WITHDRAWING Spending more time alone than you want to, avoiding messages, or repeatedly declining opportunities to connect.
02	FEELING UNSEEN Being around people but feeling misunderstood, disconnected, or as though you do not belong.
03	OVERTHINKING CONNECTION Worrying about whether people like you, whether you are being left out, or whether reaching out will be rejected.
04	LOSING ROUTINE Pulling away from activities, classes, groups, hobbies, or places that once gave you a sense of connection.

LONELINESS IS NOT ALWAYS ABOUT THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE AROUND YOU

A person may have classmates, colleagues, family members, or followers online and still feel deeply disconnected. What matters is not only contact, but whether the relationships provide enough belonging, trust, understanding, and mutual care.

Try asking yourself: “Do I need more people, deeper connection with the people I already know, or more opportunities to belong somewhere?” The answer can help you choose your next step.

SMALL WAYS TO REBUILD CONNECTION

You do not have to change your whole social life at once.

01 START WITH ONE PERSON

Send a simple message to someone you trust: "Hey, how have you been?" Connection often begins with a small opening.

02 SHOW UP SOMEWHERE REGULARLY

A club, study group, volunteer activity, faith community, sports activity, or shared-interest group can create repeated opportunities to connect.

03 LET PEOPLE KNOW YOU

Share a small honest part of your experience instead of waiting until you feel completely confident. Appropriate vulnerability can create closeness.

04 OFFER CONNECTION TOO

Ask someone how they are doing, invite them for a study session, share a meal, or include someone who may also be feeling left out.

05 KEEP TRYING AFTER AWKWARD MOMENTS

Not every interaction becomes a friendship. One uncomfortable experience does not tell you what every future connection will be like.

"A small step toward connection is still a step."

WHEN REACHING OUT FEELS DIFFICULT

If anxiety, shame, past rejection, or low confidence makes reaching out hard, start with a low-pressure action. Reply to one message. Sit with classmates instead of alone. Ask a lecturer a question after class. Join one activity for a short time. The goal is not instant friendship—it is creating opportunities for connection.

WHEN LONELINESS STARTS TO FEEL HEAVY

Support is a strength, not a failure.

01 TALK TO SOMEONE YOU TRUST

A friend, family member, mentor, lecturer, colleague, counsellor, or another trusted person can help you feel less alone with what you are carrying.

02 PROTECT YOUR ROUTINE

Keep basic routines such as sleep, meals, study, movement, and time outside when possible. Structure can make isolation less consuming.

03 LIMIT THE COMPARISON TRAP

Online posts usually show selected moments. Comparing your real life with other people's highlights can intensify feelings of being left behind.

04 ASK FOR PROFESSIONAL SUPPORT

If loneliness is persistent, overwhelming, or affecting your daily functioning, consider speaking with a mental-health professional or support service.

Remember: You do not need to wait until loneliness becomes a crisis before talking to someone. Reaching out early can be a healthy way of taking care of yourself.

BE THE PERSON WHO MAKES CONNECTION EASIER

Notice the person who is always alone. Invite rather than assume. Listen without rushing to fix. Make room for different personalities and backgrounds. Small acts of inclusion can make a community feel safer and more welcoming.

YOUR CONNECTION CHECK-IN

A few questions to help you notice what you need.

1. Who is one person I feel safe talking to?
2. Where do I feel most like I belong?
3. What kind of connection am I missing right now?
4. What is one small social step I could take this week?
5. Is there someone I could check in on?
6. What makes it difficult for me to reach out?
7. What support would make connection easier for me?

“You deserve relationships where you can be heard, respected, and yourself.”

LONELINESS CAN CHANGE. CONNECTION CAN BE BUILT.

You do not have to solve everything today. One conversation, one invitation, one shared activity, or one honest request for support can be a beginning. If the first attempt does not go as hoped, that does not mean meaningful connection is impossible.

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